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THE REPUBLIC OF LIBERIA

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December 3, 2015

MARINE SECURITY ADVISORY – 05/2015

(This Security Advisory supersedes 'Security Advisory: 02/2011, 03/2012 and 01/2013')

Subject: REVISED HIGH RISK AREA - VESSELS TRANSITING THE RED SEA, GULF OF ADEN, WESTERN INDIAN OCEAN, ARABIAN SEA and GULF OF OMAN

Reference: (a) MSC.1/Circ.1337
(b) MSC.1/Circ.1334
(c) Marine Security Advisory 02/2009

Dear Owners/Operators/Company Security Officers/Masters:

The co-sponsors of Best Management Practices to Deter Piracy off the Coast of Somalia and in the Arabian Sea Area (BMP 4) have revised Section 2 of the BMP4. The revision and accompanying guidance on the revision's impact and practical measures for implementation in the context of company and shipboard planning as described in sections 6 and 7 of BMP 4 are attached to this Advisory. The revision applies from 1 December 2015.

It is strongly recommended that Owners, Operators and their Masters take the revisions into account as soon as possible for voyages through the UKMTO Voluntary Reporting Area (VRA) and High Risk Area (HRA) for which risk assessments are yet to be conducted, as the changes may have implications for charter party and insurance agreements as well as ship security.

While the revision re-designates the HRA considered to be at a high risk of Somalia-based pirate groups, it is stressed that these groups retain the ability to attack at historical limits of their activity.

For the purpose of BMP the revised HRA is an area bounded by:

In the Red Sea:	northern limit:	Latitude 15°N
In the Gulf of Oman:	northern limit:	Latitude 22°N
Eastern limit:		Longitude 065°E
Southern limit:		Latitude 5°S

The revised HRA is now within the UKMTO designated Voluntary Reporting Area (VRA).

Vessels entering the HRA:

The provision of carefully planned and installed Ship Protection Measures (SPMS) prior to transiting the High Risk Area is required. Suggested SPMS are set out in section 8 of BMP4. The record over the years since the implementation of the BMP clearly indicates the implementation of an effective SPMS significantly increases the prospects of a ship resisting a pirate attack.

Mandatory Ship Security Level 2 shall be set when entering into and transiting inside the HRA defined above, including when departing a port within this area.

Upon change of Security Level to Ship Security Level 2, Masters should report to the Administration via email to security@liscr.com.

Vessels entering into and operating within the VRA but outside of the HRA:

The UKMTO VRA is defined as being bounded by:

Suez and the Strait of Hormuz to the North, 10°S and 78°E

It is important to note that:

1. The latest information on the location(s) where pirates are operating is to be obtained from MSCHOA & UKMTO prior to completing the voyage risk assessment (See contact details at Annex A of the BMP) and before entering the VRA.
2. Vessels should be prepared to alter course at short notice to avoid pirate activity when information is provided by NAV WARNINGS and/or Naval/Military forces.
3. Weather can also constitute an obstacle to pirates, and can be considered a factor when planning a route through the VRA and HRA.

Somalia-based pirate groups retain the ability to attack at historical limits of their activity, therefore, the Liberian Administration strongly recommends Owners, Operators and their Masters consider implementing appropriate BMP measures, as and where the risk assessment indicates their necessity, prior to entering and while operating vessels within the VRA. This may include setting of security measures equivalent to Ship Security Level 2.

1. Voyage Planning

Companies and Masters shall obtain the latest information from MSCHOA before planning and executing a voyage in the HRA and VRA and should maintain maximum distance from specified threats within the areas. The CSO shall review the Ship Security Assessment (SSA) for all Liberian flag vessels prior to their operating in the affected areas to ensure full consideration has been given to the guidance issued by the IMO, industry and military sources, including, ref (b), IMO MSC.1/Circ.1334, "Guidance to shipowners and ship operators, shipmasters and crews on preventing and suppressing acts of piracy and armed robbery against ships" and BMP4 developed by the industry."

- 1.1 Where the review of the SSA indicates that the Ship Security Plan (SSP) requires additional measures to be incorporated to counter the threat of piracy and armed robbery, the CSO should develop an Appendix to the approved SSP, setting out the relevant additional security measures, when operating in the affected area. A record of the review shall be kept on board.
- 1.2 The Appendix to the approved SSP must be placed on board with the SSP. There should be a reference to the Appendix within the SSP, which addresses security provisions for piracy and armed robbery. However, in consideration of the dynamic nature of the threat posed by piracy and armed robbery, a full SSP is not required to be re-submitted to the Administration for review and approval.
- 1.3 The Appendix will be verified by submitting an electronic copy together with a copy of the SSP index and/or amendments record sheet to the Administration before the next scheduled ISSC audit. In cases where the audit is due within one month of the date of this guidance, reasonable consideration will be given by the Administration as to the adequacy of the security measures under development. Where the appendix has been previously verified on board the vessel during an audit by a Liberian flag State auditor, this will remain acceptable in lieu of submitting an electronic copy.
- 1.4 The contents of any Appendix to the approved SSP are subject to the same unauthorized access protection and disclosure restrictions as the SSP.
- 1.5 CSO's should report within 24 hours to the Administration any incident of attempted piracy, armed robbery or any other breach of security. The report should include an assessment of the effectiveness of any measures taken by the vessel to deter the attack.

2. Registration with MSCHOA

- 2.1 Companies and Masters are **required** to register their Vessel movements with MSCHOA, even if the vessel does not enter the modified HRA. This will enable:
- 2.1.1 Access to the restricted sections of the MSCHOA website and to review the latest piracy related information contained therein.
 - 2.1.2 Group Transit coordination, if transiting through the International Recommended Transit Corridor (IRTC).
 - 2.1.3 Automatic MSCHOA issued alerts sent to the primary and secondary email addresses entered at registration, until 72 hours after exiting the VRA.
 - 2.1.4 Situational awareness of vessels transiting the VRA in case assistance of Naval/Military forces is necessary.
- 2.2 ‘Vessel Movement Registration’ with MSCHOA is required **prior to** each entry to the VRA. As an option, the data last entered for an already registered vessel may be selected and modified for future transits.

Register with MSCHOA on-line: www.mschoa.org

By email: postmaster@mschoa.org or

By fax: +44 1923 958520.

(Note: This can be done by either by the Master or the Company).

3. Reporting Scheme When Entering the UKMTO Voluntary Reporting Area

Masters of Liberian flagged vessels are **required** to participate in the Merchant Vessel Voluntary Reporting Scheme to improve responsiveness and to save time when naval assistance is required.

Masters of vessels are advised to provide an “Initial Report” to UKMTO Dubai (via Email or Fax) when entering the VRA or leaving a port within this area.

UKMTO email: ukmto@eim.ae; Fax: +971 4 306 5710; or Telex: (51)210473

A copy of the initial report should be sent to the Liberian Administration at: security@liscr.com

After transmitting the initial report to UKMTO, vessels must continue to report their daily noon position, course, speed, and ETA to UKMTO with a copy to MSCHOA, whilst operating in the HRA and VRA.

When calling at ports within the reporting area, the date/time of arrival and the ETD should be reported.

All times are requested in UTC and the preferred method of communication is email.

Reports may be made by either the vessel or by the owner/operator.

If planning to transit the Gulf of Aden, vessels are requested to add the ETA at the IRTC entry point (“Point A” or “Point B”) to the daily reports to UKMTO and MSCHOA.

Final reports should be sent when exiting the affected area.

UKMTO Standard Message Format

The initial report should contain the following information:

- Vessel Name;
- Flag;
- IMO Number;
- INMARSAT Telephone Number;
- Time and Position;
- Course;
- Passage Speed;
- Freeboard;
- Cargo;
- Destination and Estimated Time of Arrival;

- Name and contact details of Company Security Officer; and
- Nationality of Master and Crew.

4. Recommended actions in the event of suspected, or imminent, piracy attack

4.1 Suspected Piracy Activity

In the event of suspected pirate activity:

- Contact UKMTO (Phone: +971 50 552 3215, Email: ukmto@eim.ae;
- Contact MSCHOA, Phone: +44 1923958545, Fax. +441923 958520, Email: postmaster@mschoa.org;
- Contact CSO in accordance with SSP/company procedures;
- Copy the Flag Administration by Email: security@liscr.com; and
- Copy the IMB by Email: piracy@icc-ccs.org

If there is conclusive evidence that the safety of the ship is threatened, make an “All Stations” “Urgent Message” preceded by the appropriate Urgency signal (PAN-PAN) via VHF, INMARSAT C and/or DSC using the “all ships urgency” category.

4.2 Imminent Attack

Should an attack appear imminent:

- Activate the SSAS (Ship Security Alert System);
- Make a ‘Mayday’ call on VHF – 16 (and backup channel 08 which is monitored by the Naval units) and send a distress message via MF/HF DSC and INMARSAT C;
- Contact UKMTO 24 hr Duty Officer Phone: +971 50 552 3215, Email: ukmto@eim.ae;
- If no answer, contact MSCHOA, Phone: +44 1923958545, Fax. +441923 958520, Email: postmaster@mschoa.org; and
- Contact CSO in accordance with SSP/company procedures.

In addition to the above precautionary measures; Owners, Operators, and Company Security Officers should take the following actions:

- Verify compliance with internationally recognized Best Management Practices to Deter Piracy off the Coast of Somalia and in the Arabian Sea Area (BMP 4), contained in MSC.1/Circ.1337.
- Ensure that guidance issued by IMO, industry and military sources regarding piracy and armed robbery in the area have been taken into account.
- Report any incident of attempted piracy or armed robbery within 24 hours. The report should include an assessment of the effectiveness of any measures taken by the vessel to deter the attack and lessons learned.

For more information please contact the Security Department at telephone + 1 703 790 3434, email security@liscr.com

In case of an afterhours emergency please contact the LISCRC Duty Officer + 1 703 963 6216, email dutyofficer@liscr.com

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Somali Pirate Activity

The High Risk Area

2.1 The High Risk Area (HRA) is an area within the UKMTO designated Voluntary Reporting Area (VRA) where it is considered there is a higher risk of piracy and within which self-protective measures are most likely to be required. For the purpose of BMP the High Risk Area is an area bounded by:

In the Red Sea:	northern limit:	Latitude 15°N
In the Gulf of Oman:	northern limit:	Latitude 22°N
Eastern limit:		Longitude 065°E
Southern limit:		Latitude 5°S

It should be noted military threat assessments provided by SHADE indicate that the risk from Somalia-based pirates operating at range cannot be completely discounted and an increased state of readiness and vigilance may therefore be required within the VRA in accordance with individual ship voyage risk assessments which remain the cornerstone of this guidance.

2.2 It is important the latest information on the location of where pirates are operating is obtained from MSCHOA & UKMTO prior to completing the voyage risk assessment. (See contact details at Annex A) and before entering the VRA. It is also important vessels are prepared to alter course at short notice to avoid pirate activity when information is provided by NAV WARNINGS and/or Naval/ Military forces. Weather can also constitute an obstacle to pirates and can be considered a factor when planning a route through the Voluntary Reporting Area and High Risk Area itself.

2.3 It is strongly recommended that effective BMP measures are implemented as and where the risk assessment indicates their necessity.

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Supporting Guidance

The table below provides guidance on the specific application of actions in sections 6 and 7 of BMP4 by the Company and Ships master in the VRA and HRA in accordance with the new definition.

- The three fundamental requirements of BMP – Register at MSCHOA, Report to UKMTO, Implement SPMS remain unchanged;
- The pre-transit risk assessment in accordance with section 3 of BMP 4 remains essential to the safety of a ship and its crew;
- Military Threat Assessments through SHADE indicate pirates are capable of attacking at range.
- The pre transit risk assessment should therefore consider both the situation in the VRA as well as the HRA, taking into account current advice from UKMTO, MSCHOA, Coastal States and relevant NAV warnings;
- The MSCHOA Vessel Registration area remains **unchanged** and is still bounded by the Strait of Hormuz and Suez to the North, 10S and 78E. All Vessel movements should be registered with MSCHOA, even if the vessel **does not** enter the modified HRA.
- Any reference in BMP4 stating that a Vessel should register with MSCHOA prior to entering the HRA is now superseded by the bullet above.
- There is only a requirement to register with MSCHOA once.
- The output of the Risk Assessment will determine what appropriate self-protective measures are required and when and where they should be applied. It should be noted that SPMs are likely to be required in the HRA for most vessels.
- The table below provides guidance on the specific application of actions by the Company and Ships master in the VRA and HRA in accordance with the new definition.

Practical measures for implementation in the context of company and shipboard planning as described in sections 6 and 7 of BMP 4

Company Planning

Action	VRA	HRA
6.1 – Register Ship with MSCHOA Website	YES	YES
6.2 – Obtain Latest information from the MSCHOA and NATO Shipping Centre websites	YES	YES
6.3 – Review the SSA and SSP	YES	YES
6.4 – Put SSP in place	As Required	YES
6.5 – Monitor piracy related websites on specific threats	YES	YES
6.6 – Offer guidance to Master with regard to the recommended route	As Required	YES
6.7 – Plan and install Ship Protection measures	As Required	YES
6.8 - Conduct crew training	As Required	YES
6.9 – Submit “vessel Movement Registration Form” to MSCHOA	YES ¹	YES

Ship Master’s Planning

Action	VRA	HRA
7.1 – Brief crew and conduct drill	YES	YES
7.2 - Prepare and Emergency Communication Plan	YES	YES
7.3 – Define the ship’s AIS policy	YES	YES
7.4 – If Company has not submitted “Vessel Movement Registration Form” to MSCHOA	YES.	YES
7.5 – Upon Entering submit “Vessel Position Reporting Form” – Initial report to UKMTO	YES	YES
7.6 – Reduce Maintenance and engineering work to minimum	As Required	YES
7.7 – Daily submit “Vessel Position Reporting Form – Daily Position Report” to UKMTO	YES	YES
7.8 – Carefully review all warnings and information	YES	YES
7.9 – Use IRTC Group Transit Scheme while transiting through Gulf of Aden	Not Applicable	As Required
7.10 – Make Adjustments to passage plans to conform to MSCHOA advice	YES	YES
7.11 – National Convoys	Not Applicable	As Required

¹ As advised by MSCHOA